Anorexia Rarely Begins with Bones – A Collection

By Blythe Baird

Relapse

(Pg 70-71) Sometimes I miss being sick

The grimiest part of me wishes I had stayed
In that familiar city of grey and mental illness
and whatever the opposite of healing is
where there was nothing to laugh about
but plenty to write about

I've considered myself to be recovered
from my eating disorder for three years
But I still write about it in present tense
When a friend at dinner makes a casual
comment on calories, the scoreboard
in my head illuminates with numbers again.

For once, I don't want to write
about this. For the first time, I am embarrassed

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Instead of proud
of all the mad things I have done
for happiness.

Once I cut a ribbon the size I wanted to be
and wore it around like my waist like a bracelet

Bathroom scales make me feel
nostalgic
Like a scrapbook,
I flip through snapshots of my sickness,
the suppers of tobacco smoke
and red lipstick
how I used to pack my lunchbox with
floss and teeth whitening strips
Sometimes, I still paint my nails
when I'm hungry. I can't eat
until the polish is dry.

I don't want to go into more detail
because what if you mistake this poem
for an instruction manual?
I don't know how to talk
about the rabbit hole

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without accidentally inviting you

to follow me down it

INTRODUCTION

*Anorexia rarely begins with bones. . . it begins with numbers: calories, pounds, minutes, and the quiet belief that hunger is an achievement. In the United States, *nearly 28.8 million people will experience an eating disorder in their lifetime. Yet the illness often hides in plain sight; less than 6% of people with eating disorders are medically underweight, meaning many sufferers are praised for the very behaviors that are harming them.*

*The poems in this collection move through that contradiction: the way starvation can be mistaken for discipline, the way praise can deepen sickness, and the slow, difficult work of learning that **survival**, not **smallness**, is the real measure of health.*

Anorexia Rarely Begins with Bones – A Collection of poems from If My Body Could Speak by Blythe Baird

When the Fat Girl Gets Skinny

(Pg 3-6) the year of skinny pop and sugar-free jello cups

we guzzled vitamin water and vodka

toasting to high school and survival

complimenting each other's collarbones

trying diets we found on the internet:

menthol cigarettes, eating in front of a mirror,

donating blood.

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replacing meals with other practical hobbies

like making flower crowns

or fainting

wondering why I haven't had my period

in months

why breakfast tastes like

giving up

or how many more productive ways

I could have spent my time today

besides googling the calories

in the glue of a US envelope

watching *America's Next Top Model*

like the gospel,

hunching naked over a bathroom scale shrine,

crying into an empty bowl of Cocoa Puffs

because I only feel pretty

when I'm hungry

if you are not recovering,

you are dying.

EDUCATIONAL

by the time I was sixteen, I had already experienced being
clinically overweight, underweight, and obese.

as a child, ***fat*** was the first word
people used to describe me,

which didn't offend me until
I found out it was supposed to.

when I lost weight, my dad was so proud
he started carrying my before-and-after photo

in his wallet.

so relieved he could stop worrying
about me getting diabetes.

he saw a program on the news
about the epidemic with obesity

says he is ***just so glad*** to finally see me
taking care of myself.

if you develop an eating disorder
when you are already thin to begin with,

you go to the hospital.

if you develop an eating disorder
when you are not thin to begin with,

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you are a success story.

so when I evaporated, of course
everyone congratulated me
on getting healthy.

girls at school who never spoke to me before
stopped me in the hallway to ask how I did it.

I say, ***I am sick***.
They say ***No, you are***
an inspiration.

How could I not fall
in love with my illness?

With becoming the kind of silhouette
people are supposed to fall in love with?

why would I ever want to stop
being hungry

when anorexia was the most
interesting thing about me?

so, how lucky it is, now,
to be boring

the way not going to the hospital
is boring.

the way looking at an apple
and seeing only an apple, not sixty

or half an hour of sit-ups
is boring.

My story may not be as exciting as it used
to be, but at least there is nothing left
to count.

the calculator in my head
finally stopped.

I used to love the feeling of drinking water
on an empty stomach

waiting for the coolness to slip all
the way down and land in the well

not obsessed with being empty
but afraid of being full.

I used to take pride in being able to feel
cold in a warm room.

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now, I am proud I have stopped
seeking revenge on this body.

this was the year of eating
when I was hungry
without punishing myself

and I know it sounds ridiculous,
but that sh** is hard.

when I was little,
someone asked me

what I wanted to be
when I grew up,

and I said

small

I Didn't Always Salivate Over Skeletons

(Pg 8) I come over to play at my friend's house
& a chandelier of bones answers the door.
I can see each careful metal detail
of her braces poking clearly
through the skin above her top lip.
she steps on a Wii Fit balance board
& her frame is so wispy

that the system cannot detect a body.
she & I used to be fat
together

We shared whole pans of brownies
while our mothers shared concerns
regarding our weight.
we understood the many ways
a mother's shame
can haunt a daughter's body.

an image of this friend at a waterpark
in 7th grade is still imprinted in my mind:

she jumps, jangling her arms and legs
in excitement. she looks exactly like
the flat skeletons hung during Halloween
when you yank the string at the top
of its skull, causing its glow-in-the-dark
bones to clink and clank like chimes.

for years after, this was the last moment
I can remember seeing an emaciated body
& genuinely feeling worry
instead of envy.

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Eat

(Pg 72) When recovery is not all yoga mats and tea
and avacados, it is work. It is remembering
that sucking on ice cubes does not count as
supper. ***Body, forgive me.*** It is not healthy
to drink so much water that your body
becomes a bathtub your organs float in
like loofahs. ***Body, forgive me***. Trying
to ignore the caloric calculator in my head
is like trying to ignore television subtitles
and sometimes I just cant. ***Body, forgive me.***
Killing yourself slowly is still killing yourself.
wanting to die is not the same as wanting
to come home. Recovery is hard work.
Not wanting to die is hard work. Every time
you asked if I was full I heard fat, but I am
trying too hard not to do that. I am trying
not to search for the nutrition label on the back
of a birthday candle box. I am trying not to dab
my pizza with a napkin. I am trying to stop doing
things that don't make any sense. ***Body,***
forgive me. I am trying. I am trying. I am
still trying.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2023 National Qualifier – MS
2024 National Qualifier – MS
2025 National Qualifier - MS

Source information for introduction statistics

**https://www.allianceforeatingdisorders.com/eating-disorder-statistics/*

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